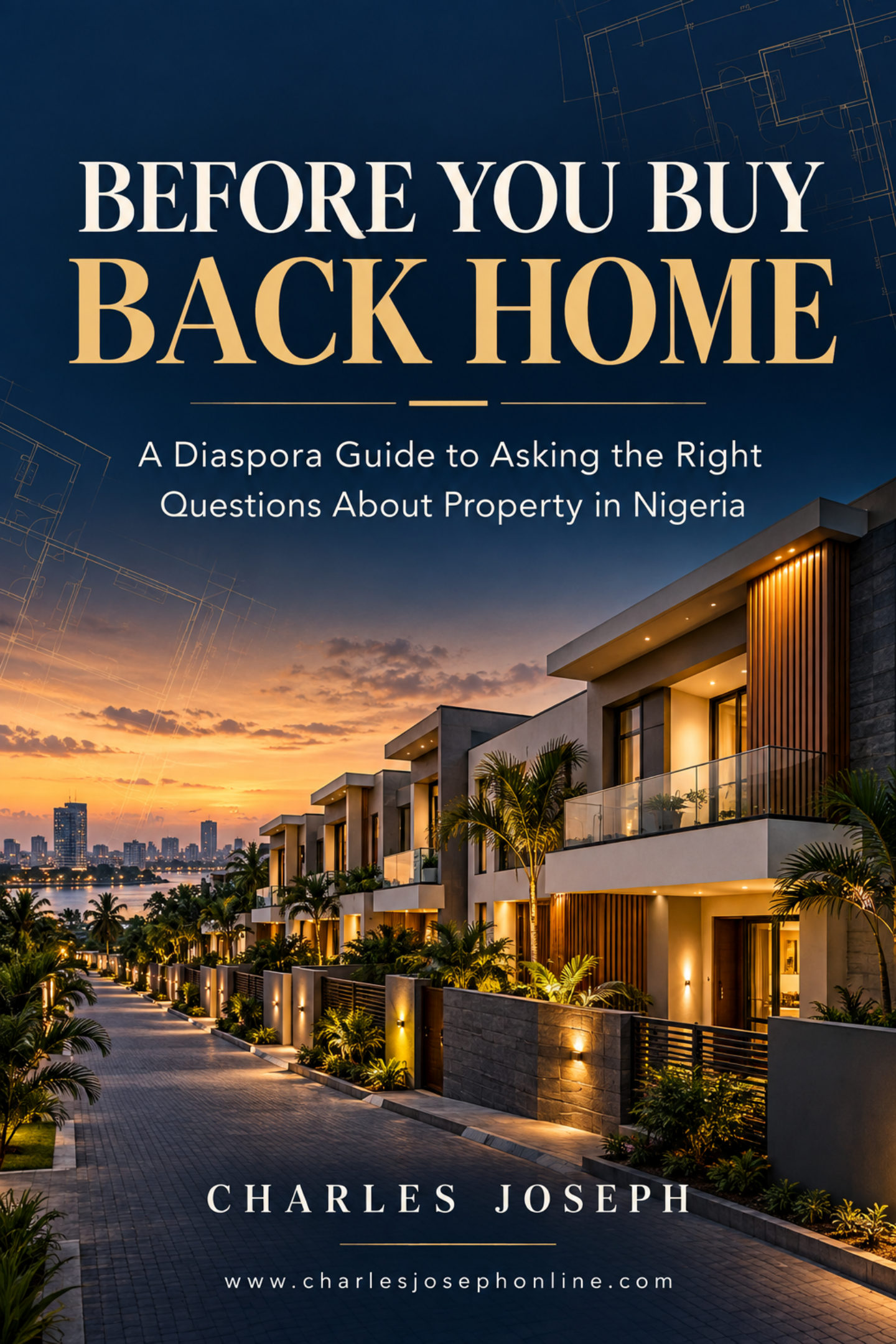
BEFORE YOU BUY BACK HOME

A Diaspora Guide to Asking the Right Questions About Property in Nigeria



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WELCOME

Before you commit your money

Buying or building a property back home can serve a genuine purpose. It can also commit years of savings to a project you cannot easily supervise. This guide helps you clarify your goal, investigate an opportunity, plan the full cost and decide what evidence you need before paying.

You do not have to finish this guide with a property purchase. You should finish with better questions and a clearer decision. Proceeding, renegotiating, postponing and walking away are all legitimate outcomes.

Make a decision you can explain

For each opportunity, write down your purpose, the evidence you have, the questions still unanswered and the financial consequences if things go badly. A decision becomes easier to assess when those four things are visible.

Use this guide with your advisers

This is an educational guide, not an assessment of any particular property or a substitute for professional advice. Requirements differ by location, property and transaction. Use qualified professionals for legal, technical, tax and financing decisions.

Cover image is illustrative and does not depict a verified property offering.

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CONTENTS

Your reading route

Read the chapters in order, then use the worksheets for the property you are considering. You can also select a section below to jump to it.

How to use this guide 4

1 Define the purpose before choosing the property 5

2 Test the location and the market 6

3 Know who is selling and who represents you 7

4 Verify the property before committing 8

5 Calculate the whole commitment 9

6 Plan the money and the payment conditions 10

7 Manage the project while living abroad 11

8 Know when to pause or walk away 12

Property readiness worksheet 13

Evidence and decision worksheet 14

Questions to take to your advisers 15

Sources and about the author 16

How to use this guide

Read the chapters before you commit to a purchase, then complete the worksheets with an actual property in mind. Record what you know, the evidence supporting it and what remains unresolved. An unanswered question should stay visible until someone competent resolves it.

The decision sequence

- Define your purpose and spending limit.
- Compare the property with realistic alternatives.
- Appoint independent professionals and complete checks.
- Assess the full cost and a disappointing outcome.
- Agree written terms and evidence for payment.
- Make your decision and establish a management plan.

What this guide covers

The focus is buying or developing property in Nigeria while living abroad. The practical questions also help with other markets, but Nigerian locations do not share one universal verification procedure. An Abuja example cannot be treated as the process for Lagos or every other state.

A note from the author

I want this guide to help members of the diaspora approach property decisions with clearer expectations and better accountability. A familiar name, attractive brochure or family connection should be the beginning of your questions, not the end of them.

I am associated with Amari Smart Living and Amaripay. This guide does not require you to purchase a property or use either business. Any future commercial proposal should be assessed separately, with independent advice and clear disclosure of relevant interests.

CHAPTER 1

Define the purpose before choosing the property

A retirement home, a rental investment and a home for relatives solve different problems. Confusing them makes it easy to justify an expensive decision with an income forecast that the property was never designed to achieve.

Write one sentence explaining the main purpose. Then set the requirements that follow from that purpose. A family home may need reliable access and proximity to support. A rental investment needs evidence of tenant demand and a workable operating budget. A development project needs execution capacity as well as capital.

Questions to answer

- Who will use the property and when?
- What amount can I commit without weakening essential household needs?
- Who will manage it when I am abroad, and what will that cost?
- How long could I hold it if selling took longer than expected?
- What alternative use of this money am I giving up?

Separate emotion from the decision

Wanting a connection to home is a valid motivation. State that honestly. Do not force the purchase to look like a profitable investment if its main value is personal. Discuss the commitment with anyone sharing the money or carrying the consequences.

Your first assignment

Complete this sentence: I am considering a property in _____ primarily for _____. My total spending ceiling is _____. I need it by _____. I would postpone if _____.

Keep this statement beside every property you review. If an opportunity only works after you change all your original requirements, reconsider whether it fits.

CHAPTER 2

Test the location and the market

A location can sound promising while the specific property is unsuitable. Investigate the exact plot, building and surrounding area. Ask what exists today, what is under construction and what is only proposed.

Compare several genuinely similar properties. Asking prices are useful starting points, but they do not establish completed sale prices or achievable rents. Record the date, property condition, size, access and source of each comparison. Ask how any quoted figure was obtained.

What to investigate

- Access in ordinary conditions and during difficult weather.
- Water, electricity, drainage, security and realistic service costs.
- The people likely to rent or buy, and why they would choose this location.
- Competing supply, vacant properties and time needed to find occupants.
- Planning or infrastructure claims and the evidence supporting them.

Check independently

Commission a site visit by someone accountable to you. Ask for dated photographs, a location record and a written report. A video call can help you ask questions, but it does not replace a technical inspection or establish ownership.

A useful comparison

For each candidate, record total expected cost, suitability for your purpose, likely operating burden and unresolved questions. A cheaper purchase can become the more expensive option once access works, repairs and management are included.

Your task: compare three properties and explain why your preferred option still makes sense if the advertised future development does not happen.

CHAPTER 3

Know who is selling and who represents you

Knowing an agent does not establish the seller’s right to sell. Knowing the seller does not establish that the property is free from competing claims. Treat identity, authority and the property itself as separate checks.

Ask for clear roles

- Who is the legal seller and who will sign the agreement?
- Is the person speaking to me an owner, agent, developer or representative?
- What evidence supports their authority?
- Who pays each adviser and who benefits if the transaction completes?
- Who can give me an independent opinion and report directly to me?

Appoint a property lawyer with relevant local experience and agree the work in writing. For physical condition and construction questions, engage the appropriate surveyor, engineer or other technical professional. Verify professional credentials through the relevant body rather than relying solely on a badge or profile.

Working with relatives

A relative can help with access and communication. Give that role clear boundaries. Specify what they may arrange, what they may spend and what needs your approval. Avoid making one person responsible for introducing the seller, verifying the property, controlling the money and confirming completion.

Illustrative situation

An agent recommends a lawyer who says everything is fine. That may be an honest arrangement, but you still need to know whom the lawyer represents, what checks were completed and whether the conclusion is in writing. A confident verbal assurance is not a documented investigation.

Keep copies of instructions, reports, agreements and payment records in a folder you control.

CHAPTER 4

Verify the property before committing

Do not treat possession of a document as proof that every part of a transaction is sound. Ask your lawyer to identify the checks required for the specific property, the relevant authorities and the issues that could prevent or complicate the purchase.

Questions for your lawyer

- What ownership documents exist, and how have they been independently checked?
- Does the seller have authority to transfer the interest being offered?
- Are there competing claims, mortgages, disputes or restrictions?
- Do the documents, survey information and physical property correspond?
- What approvals, consents, registrations or other steps apply to this transaction?
- Which questions remain unresolved, and what is the consequence of each?

Physical and planning checks

Ask the appropriate technical professionals about boundaries, access, building condition, intended use, required approvals and defects. Legal verification and physical inspection answer different questions. Completing one does not complete the other.

An Abuja example

Abuja Geographic Information Systems lists property search and land-record verification among its services and publishes a legal-search process. Your lawyer should determine the applicable checks and confirm the current requirements directly. This example is specific to the FCT and is not a universal Nigerian procedure. See the source notes at the end.

Before a deposit

If you are asked to pay before checks are complete, obtain legal advice on the proposed payment, refund conditions and remaining exposure. The label “reservation fee” does not explain what rights you receive. Understand the written terms before you commit.

CHAPTER 5

Calculate the whole commitment

The purchase price is only one line in your budget. Include professional fees, transaction costs, repairs, furnishing, utilities, management and a reserve for uncertainty. Ask qualified advisers to estimate location-specific charges rather than borrowing a percentage from an unrelated transaction.

Illustrative rental budget

These invented figures teach the calculation. They are not market estimates, recommended prices or a forecast.

Item	Illustrative amount
Purchase	NGN 60,000,000
Transaction and professional costs	NGN 4,000,000
Repairs and initial setup	NGN 6,000,000
Contingency reserve	NGN 5,000,000
Total cash allocation	NGN 75,000,000
Annual scheduled rent	NGN 6,000,000
Vacancy allowance	NGN 600,000
Annual operating expenses	NGN 1,400,000
Net operating income	NGN 4,000,000

NGN 4,000,000 divided by NGN 75,000,000 is approximately 5.3% annually before financing and tax. This uses the full cash allocation, including the reserve, as its denominator. It excludes appreciation and selling proceeds; it is not a total investment return.

If scheduled rent falls 20% to NGN 4,800,000, a 10% vacancy allowance is NGN 480,000. With unchanged operating expenses, net operating income falls to NGN 2,920,000, or about 3.9% of the allocation.

CHAPTER 6

Plan the money and the payment conditions

A property can be affordable at purchase and difficult to sustain afterward. Keep household emergency funds separate from project funds. If you borrow, calculate repayments alongside a period with no rental income and an unexpected repair.

Think in both currencies

Record the currency in which you earn, the currency of the contract and the currency of project expenses. Use current exchange quotes and include transfer costs. Test an unfavourable exchange-rate movement before deciding how much you can commit. A gain measured in naira does not automatically translate into a gain in your home currency.

Before every payment

- Identify the recipient and confirm why that recipient is entitled to receive the funds.
- Confirm account details through an independently verified contact, especially after any change.
- Link the payment to a written obligation or agreed stage.
- Specify the evidence needed and who will review it.
- Record what happens if the stage is incomplete, delayed or disputed.
- Keep the invoice, approval, payment confirmation and receipt together.

For construction, ask your technical adviser to define measurable milestones. “Work is progressing” is too vague to justify a payment. Evidence might include an inspection report, measurements and supporting photographs, depending on the work.

Understand payment arrangements

Staged payments can limit how much is committed at one time, but they do not remove risk. If a provider offers conditional release or escrow, ask who holds the funds, what the contract requires, who decides whether conditions are satisfied and how disputes or refunds are handled. Do not assume the name of a service answers those questions.

CHAPTER 7

Manage the project while living abroad

Remote management needs a reporting routine that tells you what has been done, what has been spent and what decision is needed. A stream of photographs can look reassuring while leaving the budget and workmanship unanswered.

Set responsibilities before work starts

- Contractor: carries out the agreed work and submits progress and payment requests.
- Independent technical reviewer: checks relevant work and reports to you.
- Local coordinator: arranges access and communication within written limits.
- You: approve material changes and payments using the agreed evidence.

On a small project, roles may overlap. Understand where that leaves a conflict or a gap, and arrange independent checks at the important stages.

Request a regular progress report

The report should identify work completed against the plan, spending against the budget, outstanding defects, delays, proposed changes and the next decision required. Match photographs to the work described. Agree a frequency that suits the project and a process for urgent issues.

Control changes

A small verbal instruction can create a large additional bill. Before approving a change, ask for the reason, price, effect on timing and person responsible. Keep the approval in writing. Make sure the change is reflected in the updated budget and programme.

Prepare for handover

Define completion before the last payment. Arrange an appropriate inspection, a defects list and a written process for correction. Obtain the relevant records, warranties, access items and operating information. Confirm who will maintain, insure and manage the property afterward.

CHAPTER 8

Know when to pause or walk away

Your strongest negotiating position may be your willingness to stop. Time already spent investigating a property does not make the next payment sensible.

Reasons to pause

- You cannot obtain a clear written account of the seller’s authority.
- Independent inspection or verification is discouraged.
- Names, locations, documents or payment instructions do not match.
- The deal depends on an unverified promise about future infrastructure or rent.
- The full budget exceeds your limit or leaves no workable reserve.
- Refund, completion or dispute terms remain unclear.
- You are pressured to pay before your advisers finish their work.

These issues require investigation; they do not by themselves prove fraud. However, reassurance from the person selling the property is not enough to close an unresolved concern.

Make a written decision

Use four headings: what fits my purpose; what the evidence establishes; what remains uncertain; and why I am proceeding or stopping. Ask whether you could explain the decision to someone who has no emotional attachment to the property.

If you suspect a problem after paying

Preserve messages, documents and payment records. Contact your bank or payment provider promptly about available action and speak to an appropriate lawyer. Use independently verified reporting channels. Avoid sending additional money merely because someone promises it will recover the first payment.

The Canadian Anti-Fraud Centre identifies high-pressure tactics as an investment-fraud warning sign. Its material offers general fraud guidance, not verification of a particular Nigerian property. See the source notes.

WORKSHEET 1

Your property readiness worksheet

Use this page to define your purpose and financial limits before choosing a property. Write estimates clearly and identify what needs verification.

Property location and description

Main purpose and intended users

Total spending ceiling and currency

Funding source and borrowing commitment

Expected holding period

Person responsible for local management

Conditions that would make me postpone

WORKSHEET 2

Evidence and decision worksheet

For each area, record the evidence and any unanswered question. Use a separate sheet for detailed reports.

Seller identity and authority

Evidence: _____
Open question / person responsible: _____

Ownership and legal checks

Evidence: _____
Open question / person responsible: _____

Site and technical inspection

Evidence: _____
Open question / person responsible: _____

Market and income assumptions

Evidence: _____
Open question / person responsible: _____

Budget and downside scenario

Evidence: _____
Open question / person responsible: _____

Agreement and payment conditions

Evidence: _____
Open question / person responsible: _____

Management and exit plan

Evidence: _____
Open question / person responsible: _____

Decision: Proceed / Renegotiate / Postpone / Walk away

Reason and conditions: _____
Review date / adviser: _____

Questions to take to your advisers

For the lawyer

- What precisely am I acquiring, from whom and with what restrictions?
- What checks have you completed and what remains outstanding?
- What commitments would a deposit or signature create?
- What happens if the seller cannot complete or a dispute develops?

For the technical professional

- Does the physical property match the description and relevant records?
- Which defects, access issues or approval questions need further work?
- What is a realistic scope, cost and timeline for the proposed work?
- What should be inspected before the next payment?

For the financial or tax adviser

- Can my household sustain this commitment under the downside scenario?
- Which financing, tax, reporting and cross-border issues apply to me?
- How should I compare the expected return with other uses of my money?

Your next step

Complete the readiness worksheet before asking someone whether a property is “a good deal.” Better information makes that conversation useful.

Visit www.charlesjosephonline.com for updates and information about future diaspora property learning sessions. Programme dates and participation arrangements will be announced separately.

Sources and about the author

Sources checked on 10 October 2026. Procedures can change. Ask your advisers to confirm current requirements for the actual property before acting.

Abuja Geographic Information Systems — Our Services

Open official source

Supports the FCT example concerning property searches and land-record verification.

Abuja Geographic Information Systems — Legal Search

Open official source

Publishes a legal-search process. No fees or document requirements from that process are reproduced as universal guidance here.

Canadian Anti-Fraud Centre — Investment

Open official source

General investment-fraud guidance, including high-pressure tactics.

About Charles Joseph

Charles Joseph is a community and faith leader, founder of Amari Smart Living and Amaripay, and Executive Director of Overcomer Community Development Centre. His interests include property development, diaspora engagement and greater accountability around transactions.

This guide is intended as a community education resource. It does not certify properties, guarantee returns or offer a professional opinion on an individual transaction.